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s

elizabeth bartlett

editorial jus, méxico

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of yes

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and no

elizabeth bartlett

editorial jus, méxico

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### POEMS OF YES AND NO

Elizabeth Bartlett

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**poems**  
**of**  
**yes and no**

**elizabeth bartlett**

editorial jus  
m xico

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yes, paul — with all my heart

first edition  
1952  
number  
2

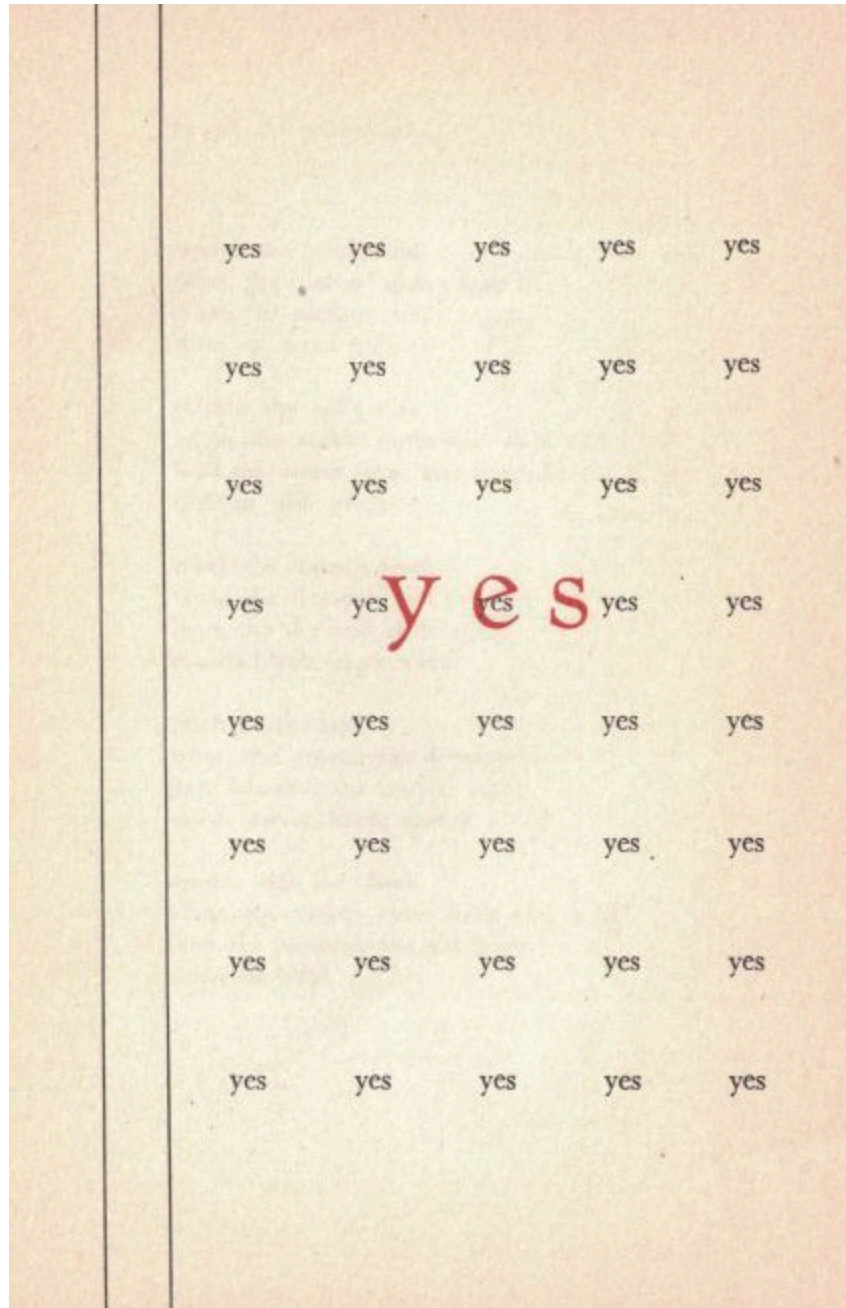
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no

step softly  
I would remember  
now and forever  
catchtraps  
beyond cost  
summer and winter  
suddenly  
item: body found  
on trial  
guadalajara  
pilgrimage  
washday in the tropics  
only this  
maturity  
alter ego  
this much I know about time  
in the wake of sleep  
cold wakening  
weather forecast  
measured interval  
black sun  
log for a voyage  
notes for the future



search the wild wind

search the wild wind  
when the foals of spring leap by  
leave the summer colts behind  
nose up, head high

stretch the hill's ribs  
when the stable gates are wide  
lead the mares from manger cribs  
stallion with pride

reach the storm's heart  
when the world is lost to sight  
buck the sky and cliffs apart  
clouds black, snow white

pitch a new tent  
when the greengrass disappears  
paw beneath the crystal scent  
sweet leaves, fresh spears

march with the dawn  
when the nights grow long and cold  
seek for pastures not yet born  
rider, be bold

lesson on five fingers

now that I have learned  
how seasons are returned  
brook my laughter here  
to the running years  
waterfall the fears

now that I realize  
how much the world denies  
green my sense leaves bright  
to chlorophyl of light  
photocell the nights

now that I have found  
how each must choose his ground  
terrace my piece of time  
to a hill of sweet limes  
stairway the climb

now that I have seen  
how cunning walks between  
mountain my trust high  
to the pigmy wise  
landslide the lies

now that I understand  
how heart unites with hand  
radar the future free  
to the dove singing me  
laurel the peace

journey to jerusalem

sky our thoughts to midnight  
that hold no noon's repose  
silence speaks in clearer voice  
than day's tumultuous crows

unpave the streets to earthscape  
grass pillow to our heads  
as virgin stars attend once more  
moon music forested

mountain our hearts to the lion  
tender our hands to the dove  
olive the branch over zion  
to israelite our love

flower this hope to the springtime  
summer our dream with its fruit  
festive the fields in the autumn  
winter the future's root

prayer for four seasons

rain, rain on me  
make me green  
as lettuce leaf  
at spring's fresh core

sun, shine on me  
burn me bright  
as coral reef  
on island shore

wind, blow on me  
sweep me clean  
as grain fields tall  
for autumn's mill

stars, sing for me  
lark the night  
as snowflakes fall  
on woods and hill

ekstasis

all the hills of the world lie here  
    aeolus ride your winds  
the skybound clouds leap out like deer  
    daedalus fly your wings

the fields are green with sun and shade  
    pegasus strike your hoof  
the silence sings, the people fade  
    hesperus light my roof

the ocean's wide and far away  
    tantalus drink your fill  
no distant lands draw me astray  
    orpheus bring your skill

olympus is within my heart  
    poetry lift me high  
with pagan joy I sing my art  
    melody till I die

challenge

tell me, in this high land of mountained length  
where time is green and space big-bellied  
with fruitful plains rockribbed by corn and bean  
for simple courage, do you know strength  
as something earned through bitterness of need  
in narrow streets and tortured rooms, oh hungry lean

listen, above the winding road come sounds  
descending on bells, sky voices and wind  
mixing with the shy four footed ones' cries,  
what do they tell, can you hear from the grounds  
of city skyscrapers through the tunnelthinned  
walls that rail the nervetracked brain with wooden ties

look you, whose eyes are wise with too much seen  
through doors and windows, in whom the sunlight  
is confined by steel canyons and arctic  
nights, here is heart space, here clouds rise between  
warm currents to open roofs, see how the height  
of climb and width of free brightens to tropic

taste this, you tongue lovers, you gourmets, you  
who know the ends for which the palette buds  
bloom to burst on a thousand sauces, wines,  
rare meats and molded cheeses, what brew  
is this, what essence extracted from muds  
and rooted origins of leaf that taste defines

breathe, ah breathe again, purge out the unclear  
lungs, the downbent head, smell has other use  
than multiplies in shop and factory  
to substitute the sense, no need to fear  
the pure air here, to hide subtle and obtuse  
behind the mob's excuse, here the wind blows free

reach out, know touch as up and down, the span  
of head to heel, thigh to shoulder, each side  
with rough of bark to blossom, stone to dust,  
how else but by the feel, the real, can man  
press nature to his will and impel his pride  
in shaping to his needs an earth which he can trust

go up, your feet will take you high above  
streets and buildings to a new position  
forget the old appointments, you have a more  
important one with God to measure love  
not by the scrupled ways of acquisition  
but freely as the stars that follow and explore

while I live

my love is a hart seeking the waterfall  
where he may press two lips against its crystal  
depths—see how he leaps to kiss the imaged mist  
that bubbles up beneath him—he staggers, kissed

my love is an alpine trail that mountains climb  
above clouds and timber to heights out of time  
and measure—no distance there or memory  
for weak foot and tired brain—but death only

my love is a trumpet sustaining its call  
to the last clear breath—listen, the interval,  
out of canyon silences, on the dry wind,  
the throat of night catches, its echoes are thinned

my love is a dream where childhood fell asleep  
beckoned by shadows that lengthen as they creep;  
now she sighs, weeps, losing her way—morning wakes  
the sleeper and she smiles, her eyes are lakes

odyssey

ah never say the dreams were false  
that boy and girl were madly bold  
not time but timeless changes all  
man and woman we should know

what we dreamed was what we were  
and could not timeless be  
two strange wild things in universe  
too tame for altering

then let them keep without reserve  
the wings they had prepared  
and while we walk a humbled earth  
see them with spirit dare

life I love

life I love who know the heart's unease  
the mind's disease, the search unending

to a blind conclusion

I have gone so many ways  
towards praise, away from blame  
to find seclusion

known coldest doubt and passionate release  
the after peace of countless wars grown tired  
by their own diffusion

how many changes seen: chance days  
nights, the grays of violent and tame  
mixed in the time's confusion

dreamed plans, wished hopes without cease  
no single piece of life sought  
without delusion

and yet have loved each coming, going blaze  
each phase, willed and thrilled to every flame  
that brightened the illusion

then let me know death as one who foresees  
breath's end to seize a new beginning  
through the soul's transfusion

mood on a string

again the after rain and shine of night  
when mellow yellow patternings of light  
make rivers run through streets of mirrors bright  
to where the air brings thought from its seclude

as though a silver magnet drew a rood  
about the mind's internal solitude

then is the darkness gentle to my sight  
with glossy lamps to toss me into flight  
and give to sleep the freeness of a kite  
that after storm can rise in amplitude  
above the clinging wet still unsubdued  
to sail in lonely splendor wind pursued

time is a palette

each day has its color  
radiates  
each day its own color  
on the wheel  
endlessly

and they are wrong who say  
all colors are gray  
they are blind  
or else  
unimaginatively

well I remember the primary days  
the reds and yellows and blues  
those brilliant saturated hues  
each its own bright self  
intensively

a day red as a ripe warm plum  
on the mouth

staining chin and blouse with summer  
while leaves on a red tree flamed  
in crimson joy  
shamelessly

and there were other reds  
for feathers dipped in blood  
to sign youth's honor on a windless sky  
running over rooftops  
most solemn-eyed  
earnestly

or red for something velvet deep  
over quivering flesh and trembling hair  
stabbing the breath  
with a wild commotion  
like coroncitas on a christmas tree  
ecstatically

a vivid red each time  
coloring morning to evening canvas  
of that particular day  
connecting sleep with sleep  
in the intimate dye  
imperishably

yellow was first word for gold  
then sun  
and it was always rich  
like the promise of a wedding ring  
or shining birthday coin  
inevitably

yellow was wish  
more often than anything seen or heard  
except for the canary my father kept  
as his own yellow sign

pure and unalloyed  
incorruptibly

mostly it was feeling  
the evidence and substance in one  
symbol of perfection and as rare  
when harsh-cold-rough were there  
it wasn't yellow  
changelessly

precious as treasure  
awarded by the gods to saint and hero  
like the holy grail  
the lost chord  
those unrecoverable legends  
fabulously

blue was definite  
less temperamental than red  
more tangible than yellow  
like summer sigh or puff of winter air  
the outlines of dawn to dusk  
distinguishably

blue was practical and necessary  
like the blueing used in my mother's wash  
like smoke  
water air and sky blue  
for everything clear and understandable  
unmistakably

but blue had magic too  
meaning giant ships and giant fish  
rockets to the moon and planet shores  
too big and far away  
too terribly true  
incredibly

a glamorous color blue  
suing cinderella's glass slipper  
forget me nots and chinese porcelain  
and once I found a blue shell  
so fragile I let it crumble on the sand  
irretrievably

but even the primary colors  
are not all the colors  
and each day has its color  
each day radiates its own color  
on the wheel  
endlessly

and they are wrong who say  
all colors are gray  
unable to remember  
unwilling to separate  
with desperate impatience  
unimaginatively

dusk I love

dusk I love who know the morning's light  
the night's darkness, the black and white  
of yes and no and all false and true

I have lived with definite so long  
with wrong and right, with weak and strong  
with how much undefined dusk by you

for I have seen the between hours  
when towers grew soft as flowers  
and cold stones were stemmed in warmest hue

and I have watched a kind gentle grace  
take place behind the coarser face  
unloose the many masks old and new

I too felt the purple air's dissent  
from meant purpose and clear intent  
nothing certain but a changing view

then let me have time's dusk perspective  
to give the life men think they live  
an outer shape and an inner clue

the lovers

after the sunlight over barren fields  
after the dry wind through stony creeks  
we found our little green where lilies were  
and knee deep oxen stood watching us  
triumphant under trees... for this was peace  
as nature meant nature's peace to be  
with fertile soil made ready by its need  
with instincts tamed in gentler ways than fear  
with freedom measured freely as the sky  
measures breath... we lay there side by side  
breathing kisses, feeling the wet and cool  
of bodies grassed in loving, each a groove  
within a groove seeking counterpart  
with close-open-close, with light in dark

and waves lapping... we heard the overflow  
of lake on buttressed dam down sluiced walls  
making music in ditches, singing birth  
to stalks in the earth, with giant surge  
of up and out bringing humanity  
a greater day for love... then happily  
we rose and barefoot walked the golden green  
to where horses and men waded beneath  
multifoliate rays of setting sun  
their work done before the darkness come  
to cheat them... together all of us swam  
glad for the fresh clean water which ran  
on hands and hoofs, on flesh and hide, like beams  
bathing between, feeling our oneness sweet  
reward, for the sun was a broken sword  
pointing the peace towards our tomorrow

whatever else may be

as long as you're happy  
there were flowers on the street  
and sweetmeats at noon  
and a high wind in the towers  
ceaselessly

as long as you're happy  
there were mornings in the sun  
and nights in the moon  
and a magic in the warnings  
heedlessly

as long as it was long  
heart was head and hands were feet  
heat was heavy, still  
and words were trees with roots of red  
urgently

as long as—happy song  
wish was flight and new worlds won  
space was empty, chill  
and lips were birds with feathers light  
fervently

for long is as long as  
life is as strong as  
ah to be happy and free

tropic time

here before old leaves go  
new leaves come in  
here before old loves know  
new loves begin

now when the year's one spring  
no season chills  
now when the fear's one thing  
no reason kills

this is time after then  
there was regret  
this time is laughter when  
where we forget

stormbird

the winds have abated and the rain  
now the lonely dark comes again  
with blue lines running in the mind  
with hands explorative and blind

(was it the bitter taste of smoke  
or pepper berries? lips parted spoke  
words out of kisses bringing fears  
no nearer to relief than tears)

now memory is of lightning, flares  
in the night, with darkeyed cares  
encircling universes strange  
as the skies through which they range

thunder removes to distant space—  
from quiet woods where ancient grace  
roots tree in soil and lake is mild  
only the stormbird's flight is wild

the wind and the rain

thoughts in my head  
like wind through pines

lift to north  
veer to south  
shift to east  
rear to west

the wind not the pines  
till my thoughts are dead

love in my heart  
like rain on dust

stirs to dawn  
dries to noon  
whirs to dusk  
cries to night

the rain not the dust  
till my love depart

art

worthier than words the meaning kiss  
which makes true poetry of lips  
which sets a wisdom into rhyme  
no pen can simulate by line

music has cadence but heartbeats sound  
what no ear ever tuned beyond  
a harmony so fully sensed  
that voice is mute with instrument

imperative to move the dancer's arms  
would free the body from those bonds  
wherein an inner rhythm leaps  
secret with wonder, flow and cease

the eye's canvas such beauty lights  
of shade and color and design  
that brush must hesitate to set  
a lesser skill on palimpsest

yet kiss is brief and heartbeat slows  
while freedom captivates us most  
and beauty turns to counterfeit  
the images lost in memory's mist

diary

returning miles of space  
can you find the precise hour  
travel through that day  
locate the very moment  
ago there

the train goes back and forth  
stops at what time stations  
monday morning january tenth  
autumn ten years  
ago then

the boat arrives departs  
ticket pier cabin port  
pre-war london paris rome

before the depression  
remember where

the plane roars lifts the earth  
speeds me a century  
past sound past light  
we know the way back  
remember when

and buses taxis subways trams  
for how long how far conversations  
so much so many who and what  
and love and life and yes again  
name place date pen

grass flesh

the deep of night is crept upon our talk  
and what we had to say the wind will keep  
until our tongues can thrust up through the stalk  
and stay the light; meanwhile let silence sleep  
between us remembering what we were  
before our eyes were covered by the dark  
lovers who saw beauty in each other  
and from the clay drew forth an hour's spark

that hour can not die, though we must lie  
with stiffened arms about an earth which turned  
about us once to prove how much of sky  
there is in love's embrace; our kisses burned  
the millioned lightyeared stars that now must roam  
the space of all eternity till dust

can rise on flaming wings to plume the dome  
with fires kindled by our mortal lust

what triumphs we have known within the mesh  
of failure, time can not scrape from our bones;  
out of the pregnant dreams of our grass flesh  
a fertile spring will issue from the stones  
and flower like our songs in crimson mirth;  
each hidden sense that death but borrows here  
to bring about its own more perfect birth  
with quickened breath will help new life appear

the now and here

the sunlit trees along the quiet street  
enclose the afternoon on either side  
their shadows dark and still the dozing heat  
and there is no morning or night to hide

it might be anywhere the now and here  
when the heart is simple and forgets the brain  
in france on a river or a hill in spain  
when life was peaceful and there was no fear

the reminiscent chord the piano strikes  
returns us again to the slow learned ease  
of oars on a boat and the long road hikes  
the faces and voices like melodies

then old folks gladdened the spry basque dances  
as student groups mingled to learn quaint ways

and families gathered for shore holidays  
with poppies in the sun and vins des provences

in the city of the mind thoughts like these  
graze quietly in distant valleys  
as though time's gaps lay between a range  
of sunlit afternoons that never change

swallows return

o spring thaw out my winter's chill  
so cold I might be buried still  
beneath the snow

long years I lay as one whose night  
strong arms had banished from the light  
to mute my song

now wake me from oblivion  
bow down and lift me to the sun  
like earth to plow

prepare for me some green retreat  
enough for summer to complete  
its ecstasy

let autumn shake its leaves at me  
set laughter whirling from each tree  
and I forget

then should my winter come at last  
when darkened shadows overcast

the fields of men

I'll gladly say goodbye and go  
while memories warm me with their glow  
across the stile

for every year my dust shall rise  
o'er mud and rust to welcome skies  
where swallows soar

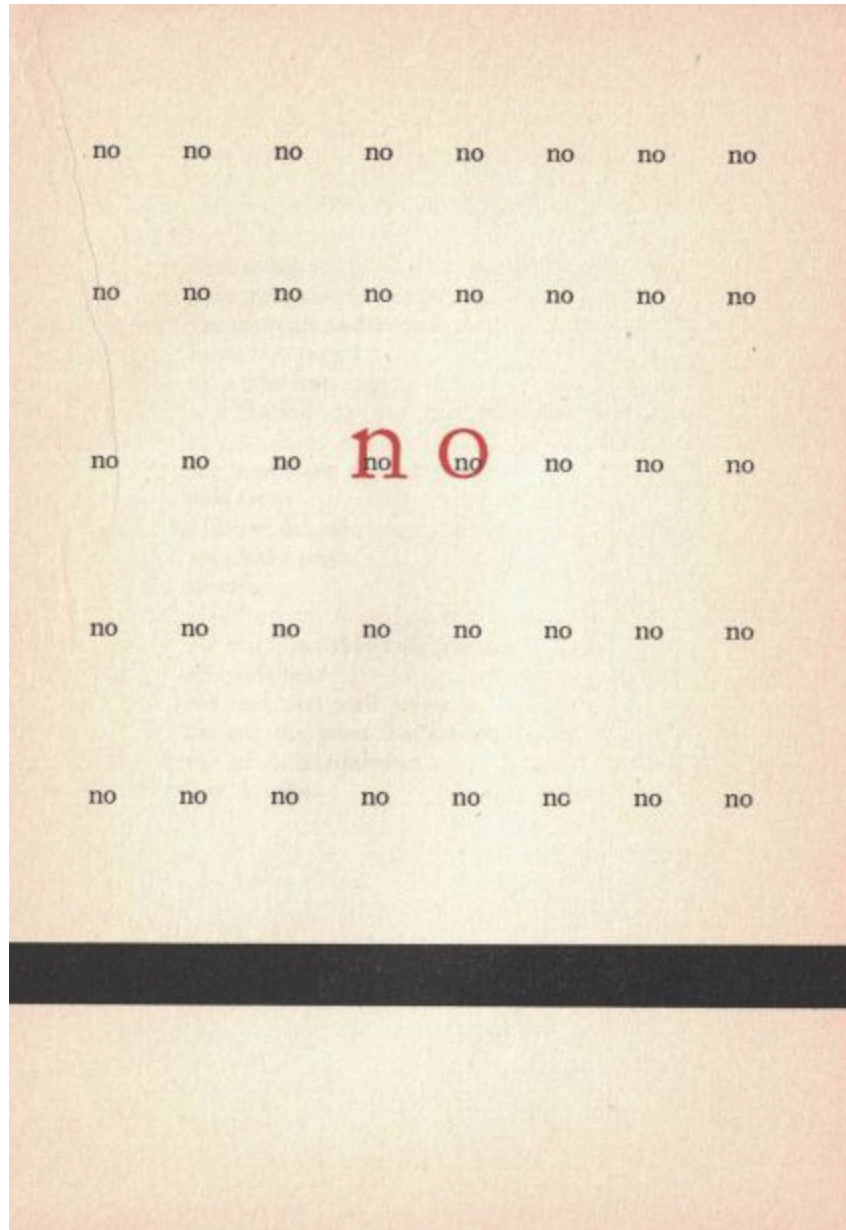
reply to critics

tell them who scorn my ways  
I lived without their praise  
and will until I die

let them be cynical  
I have my own faith still  
to question and deny

the proud and stiff of neck  
the small who grub and peck  
both look too low or high

while I but seek to know  
the feel of things that grow  
and by my living why



step softly

step softly  
your feet are on my heart  
the sawdust underneath  
hurts less than I  
even sawdust, dry  
and dirtied by our not particular feet

it's something deep inside  
that aches  
I know not why  
unless the pride  
mistakes

for the heart that only guesses  
still will bear  
the feet that walk upon it  
but not the heart that knows  
too often it confesses  
and breaks

I would remember

I have walked from river's end to end  
a slow companion to the light seagulls  
that circle overhead

and I have stood still above the bend  
that separates the foot from distant hulls  
to fill my eye with flying sails wings spread

I have watched them many times from where  
the far shore curves around the sun

and holds it there ensnared

while they advanced then dropped midair  
instinct with seaward gravitation  
and hungry claws prepared

their wings some shimmering things  
the wind has caught and suddenly flings  
in a rain of gold

I am not old  
and yet when night brings me to town  
I forget their wings and drown

now and forever

now might I keep you forever thus unchanged  
against the eventual day for both of us arranged  
when the rude winds shall bring  
no promise of another spring  
but cold and comfortless satisfaction  
the grave's discreet and quiet action  
I would not mind the days precisioned  
to the clock's unwinding  
flesh to flesh binding  
would find some way as yet unvisioned  
some way to forget  
the fever and the sweat  
here where lovers have known  
the soft of hair and hard of bone  
hearing each other moan  
a way more conscionably kind

for a night's repose  
but time defined  
forbids us to dispose  
of even one brief moment that has passed  
or keep the moment thus forever fast

catchtraps

we knew the words before we knew their meaning  
who asked so many whys while still in weaning

how many pitfalls marked with skull and crossbones  
to outwit those who lay beneath the moss stones

then set about to verify the answers  
seeking in us the cause of others' cancers

so found ourselves new victims of time's catchtraps  
and now must moan and curse until the latch snaps

beyond cost

darling don't be lost to me  
the fear was there  
under the sleeve  
lifting the hair

darling don't be lost to me

it was a prayer  
caught like a leaf  
burning in air

darling you are tossed from me

the year is bare  
wonder and grief  
drifting to where

darling you are tossed from me

what here more rare  
thought like a thief  
turning to stare

summer and winter

so many years of many seasons  
we saw and found together  
snapped grassroots trembling to the spring  
plucked berries out of harvesting  
caught swirling autumn down from trees  
about us drew a sunbright frieze  
oh summer was our weather  
but winter was in our hearts

how many years of many reasons  
convinced us not to part  
remembering the search for first green bud  
the rain paths rainbowed in the mud  
the cheep behind the window ledge  
the shutter like a moonshined wedge

oh summer was our weather  
but winter was in our hearts

too many years, too many years  
we lived and loved together  
for oh my dear the winter fears  
destroyed the summer weather  
for doubts can frost and worries blight  
the careful seed, the ripened stacks  
and questions when they come by night  
leave barren fields behind their tracks

suddenly

there was sun and moon and stars  
and night and day  
all taken for granted

then no sun no moon no stars  
no night no day  
forsaken transplanted

there was sight and sound and touch  
and someone there  
as always forever

then an empty silence such  
as none aware  
of hallways to never

item: body found

it was a silent evening I remember  
through the river's mist it comes to me  
a star pierced the air, white with speed  
it leaped across the sky, slipped and fell  
I heard its cry, it echoed in the sea  
the swift wild cry of the scornful ember

alone I stood there, never had I need  
of fellow rebel more, I a rebel  
down the dark beach I ran, I stripped, time  
was an eyeless reach across immensity  
and I plunged deeply, they blamed it on the tide  
the night, they had not seen infinity  
like a vast unchanging vista wide  
before me. if you go too far you'll drown  
they said, ah no, they know the sublime  
who reach for the falling star and go down

on trial

the day to day commitment to failure  
that judgment daily argues against me  
condemns me to despair... I am guilty  
of more than silence... at times words fail your  
wisest men and then intentionally...  
but my silence like all my secrecies

has no defense, none conventionally,  
my personal idiosyncrasies  
no social crimes... when pride is pain and shame  
an agony too keen for reason I  
had no other weapon, who is to blame?  
there was no intent to deceive or lie...  
my absence is sufficient evidence,  
voluntary exile, not providence

guadalajara

water running over stone  
    overrun my heart  
water running over stone  
    overcome my start

now wear down my sorrow  
    wash away my fears  
I have mourned tomorrow  
    widowed by the years

(water running over stone  
hard it is to be alone)

water running over stone  
    canyon deep inside  
water running over stone  
    canyon steep and wide

now let a river flow  
    strong and continuous

out of the desert grow  
green bouldered oasis

(flat and dry of emery  
plateaus on my memory)

water running over stone  
be the blood within my bone  
water running over stone  
take me and make me your own

pilgrimage

now that the flame has died which burned in us  
burned too intense for living with, beside  
and we have cooled to the quieter dust  
so comfortably and separately you and I

let us lift to the wind and drift from our pyre  
as passionlessly and still as those destined  
candles of the mind whose pilgrimage through night  
ends with a dawn cold white and all their flames relit

washday in the tropics

the sun tropics down my days  
with heat of roof and balcony

drying me out like morning's wash  
on mudbaked brick and shrubbery

the clouds are bleached by lye and ash  
to make a stiff and faultless sky  
and spotless leaves hang limp on trees  
without the energy to die

flies buzz... cock calls... the hammock swings  
with eye asquint to palmribbed light  
while smoke coughs up the desert air  
between straw sips of cool and white

where cactus pricks the sunscorched haze  
against the rainless afternoon  
three zopilotes sit and wait  
to pick apart the carcass moon

and still more scrub of soap on stone  
with slap and shake and fling of wrist  
though I unsmooth each ironed piece  
before night creeps along the mist

only this

I return to old complaints  
like the earth to its seasons  
the church has its saints  
and I my reasons

one needs to know trees  
their leaves, bark and roots

to perceive what one sees—  
the mind has no shoots

only this: the older I grow  
the more I feel, not know  
the need of believing—  
my youth is leaving

maturity

for years I watched it grow  
in thought and shape a man  
though it was smaller then and mild  
I was in fact a gentle child

the words it spoke were songs  
the air it breathed seemed sweet  
its eyes saw more than was to see  
the world I loved was meant for me

each day it woke the sun  
and played till time had tired  
then put the night to sleep in bed  
I dreamed the sky was underhead

when it was glad I joyed  
when it was sad I grieved  
joy and grief were never lonely  
I had myself for company

the seasons came and went  
and with them went we two

the fallen leaves now memories  
of years grown thick as forest trees

till knowledge found us there  
and taught us false from true  
how much the simple lesson cost  
I gained a world not worth the lost

alter ego

always He was there  
facing me  
where the others could not see  
they never believed me

He stood in the shadows  
like a tree  
posed in sunlight  
when the woods are darkly bright  
but they saw only  
black and white  
as I impatiently  
cried fools are you blind  
they looked at me  
their eyes were not unkind

when He spoke  
I heard each word  
distinctly spoken  
the silence broken  
was what He said  
but they only shook their heads

as I repeatedly  
cried fools can't you hear  
gently they answered me  
your voice is clear

when He wept  
they wiped my tears  
kept me consoled  
for the pain He felt  
fools are you so old  
you have no fears,  
have you no heart  
that grief can melt  
I insisted through the years  
but they would not depart

when He slipped  
they caught me in their arms  
ripped the garments from my wound  
and staunched the flow  
fools let me go let me go  
I shouted in alarm  
as He swooned  
and still they did not see  
the shadows by the tree  
they never believed me

then He was dying  
and I knew  
dying too  
that they would bury me there  
beside the tree  
where no one else could see  
but the fools were crying  
because I was lying so quietly  
watching the shadows  
and waiting

this much I know about time

there is safety  
only in the heart  
guard it well  
my love

where is beauty  
lonely in the mart  
hard to sell  
my dove

fame is rider  
pawing wind and cloud  
fool to reach  
so far

blame is spider  
drawing in the crowd  
cruel of speech  
they are

joys are token  
mainly for regret  
high the score  
I played

toys are broken  
plainly to forget  
buy no more  
I said

breath is fearless  
bolder than the mind  
few will sight  
my spire

death is cheerless  
colder than the wind  
who will light  
my fire

in the wake of sleep

storm in the brain whips the dull season high  
while dunes of repetition pile against the night  
sandscarred to flight... hurriedly the shore  
frightened by tide sliding out from cat's paw  
scurries behind land's door, turns key in lock  
and dims the light... now wind and rain can rock  
the mind to a wild ship's bow, ride down a mile  
climb up a wall to mountain height of sky...

dreams crash each side, tear anchor loose from sleep  
and madly race the lightning out to sea...  
everything changes: hands feet eyes the face  
of storm, all composition of the gray  
sameness, walls razed, roofs blown, the no of drought  
flooded out... the revenging dog barks loud  
across the fog and we wake to the nightmare  
violence of day, salt in mouth, sand in hair

cold wakening

for thirty years I lived a dream  
until I woke up with a scream  
and saw that all the things I'd dreamt  
had vanished in the dawn's contempt

it was not I within the glass  
it was my mother's face alas  
a face so changed from mine I'd known  
I thought the years had turned to stone

and where were all my innocence  
my glad beliefs and magic pence  
that I had saved to travel through  
a timeless world where dreams come true?

not anything inside my hand  
no moment's evidence of sand  
just grayish pulp to make me damn  
the heartless proof I think, I am?

the dream is gone and still as ice  
that glaciers down some mountain splice  
and I am carried underneath  
with stones to cling to by my teeth

weather forecast

always before the final terror  
a luscious peace  
not yet the signal bell  
not yet the swift alarm  
the sleeper has another hour  
the worker has a holiday  
still eases the dawn forward  
still comes the morning toward  
open the cities' piers  
open frontiers  
an early spring  
being everything  
the last kiss like the first  
the best without the worst

always after the initial fear  
a new release  
not yet the sharp compel  
not yet the threatened harm  
the body has a lazy power  
the brain has an agile way  
so warm the fireside within  
so rich the harvest every bin  
secure the outer walls  
secure the stalls  
a deep serenity  
without enmity  
the first signs like the last  
the future in the past

measured interval

the morning speeds to a full stop  
lands in the park  
and lights a cigarette—  
still fifteen minutes to burn  
and then noon

the train comes along, drops  
through the darkness  
and forgets—  
till five o'clock returns  
and the news

night wakes with a gong  
rings bells in the brain  
and runs off shouting—  
sleep dresses itself  
and wakes, shaking

skies ricochet downward, prong  
ciliate streaks of rain  
with gun shells routing—  
a mad head on a shelf  
laughs, breaking

now the moon blankets over the dead  
the warmth their lover bodies were denied

they lie on alien bed  
who failed to live  
who tried, whose eyes are wide  
to heaven knows what stars  
what glories fugitive

o tell me mars  
to every action  
is there an equal  
and opposite reaction

black sun

the night is white, ah strange  
the world I knew grown changed  
for sun is black with days  
I can not see amazed

all has reversed, gone void  
each thought a masked deploy  
confusing sense: heat cold  
more less, body and soul

only the light of dreams  
in which I stand blasphemed  
lost blind, a sack of straw  
facing windy mouths abhorred  
land is accursed, sea slimed  
with foulest human crimes  
at what expense to hide  
the fratricidal eye

the ghosts of years file past  
like candles in a glass  
and I a sound unheard  
to stop the murderer

dawn chanticleers no peace  
there is no west no east  
space closes round the speck  
man claims as architect

log for a voyage

we have taken to words on page  
without speech  
we have taken to birds in cage  
within reach

forsaken the meaning of lips  
forsaken the free wing that dips

we have shaken the fruitful tree  
of belief  
we have shaken the brutal sea  
for relief

mistaken the evils of sin  
mistaken the wheels that spin

then who of us shall slake the salt wound  
on the tongue  
who shall wake the nightingales marooned  
here among

o wander the world for the garden that lies  
on the floor of atlantis or roof of the skies

from its seed breed a new race of life loving men  
from its reed and papyrus make music again

notes for the future

light destroyed by minds  
only the stars

might destroyed by hands  
only the stones

no other language but signs  
no other knowledge but clans

time reduced by fear  
only the sun

space reduced by force  
only the hunt

each one yoked from head to knee  
each one racked by tooth and claw

ears condemned to hope  
only the drum

eyes condemned to ape  
only the dream

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## ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Elizabeth Bartlett (1911-1994) was an American poet and writer noted for her lyrical and symbolic poetry, creation of the new twelve-tone form of poetry, founder of the international non-profit organization Literary Olympics, Inc., and known as an author of fiction, essays, reviews, translations, and as an editor. She is not to be confused with the British poet (1924-2008) of the same name. For more detailed information about her life, work, and critical commendations, see the Wikipedia article [http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Elizabeth Bartlett %28American poet%29](http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Elizabeth_Bartlett_%28American_poet%29).

Bartlett's most notable achievements include:

- Creation of a new form of poetry, "the twelve-tone poem," adapting Arnold Schonberg's musical system to the verbal, accented sounds of language. Called "the Emily Dickinson of the 20th Century," her concise lyrics have been praised by poets, musicians, and composers alike.
- Publication of 16 books of poetry, a group of edited anthologies, and more than 1,000 poems, short stories, and essays published, for example, in *Harper's*, *Virginia Quarterly*, *New York Times*, *North American Review*, *Saturday Review*, *Prairie Schooner*, and in numerous international collections.
- Recipient of many fellowships, grants and awards, including NEA, PEN Syndicate, fellowships at the Huntington Hartford Foundation, Montalvo, Yaddo, MacDowell, Dorland Mt. Colony and Ragdale, travel grants, and honors for introducing literature as part of the Olympics.
- Founder of the Literary Olympics, to restore literature, specifically poetry, as a vital part of the Olympics as it once had been in ancient Greece.

Bartlett's poetry came to the attention of leading poets, writers, and critics as diverse as Marianne Moore, Wallace Stevens, Mark Van Doren, Conrad Aiken, Allen Tate, Alfred Kreymborg, Robert Hillyer, Louis Untermeyer, Rolfe Humphries, John Ciardi, Richard Eberhart, Richard Wilbur, Maxine Kumin, Robert M. Hutchins, Kenneth Rexroth, William Stafford, and others. Over the years, Bartlett maintained an active and extensive correspondence with eminent poets, writers, and literary critics; evident throughout this collected literary correspondence are strong statements attesting to the importance of her work.

About her first book of poetry, *Poems of Yes and No*, Marianne Moore wrote: "I surely find good in the *Poems of Yes and No*.... The clearness of the book is certainly beautiful." Wallace Stevens was impressed by *Poems of Yes and No* and wrote: "Your poems give one a sense of intelligence and sensibility." Alfred Kreymborg was enthusiastic about the book: "You have found a style of your own and developed it. I say yes to your *Poems of Yes and No*. This is a distinguished volume as a whole. I wish you well with this warm book. Any poet might envy the courage and artistry of what you say, or rather sing, there." Further commendation came from Robert Hillyer, who wrote: "Your poems are moving and unusual.... A distinguished achievement!"

Her husband, Paul Alexander Bartlett (1909-1990) was an American writer, artist, and poet. He made a large-scale study of more than 350 Mexican haciendas, published novels, short stories, and poetry, and worked as a fine artist in a variety of media. For more detailed information about his life and work, see the Wikipedia article [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Paul\\_Alexander\\_Bartlett](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Paul_Alexander_Bartlett).

Elizabeth Bartlett's son, Steven James Bartlett (1945- ), is a psychologist and philosopher who has published many books and articles in the fields of philosophy and psychology. For more detailed information about his life and work, see the Wikipedia article [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Steven\\_James\\_Bartlett](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Steven_James_Bartlett).



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